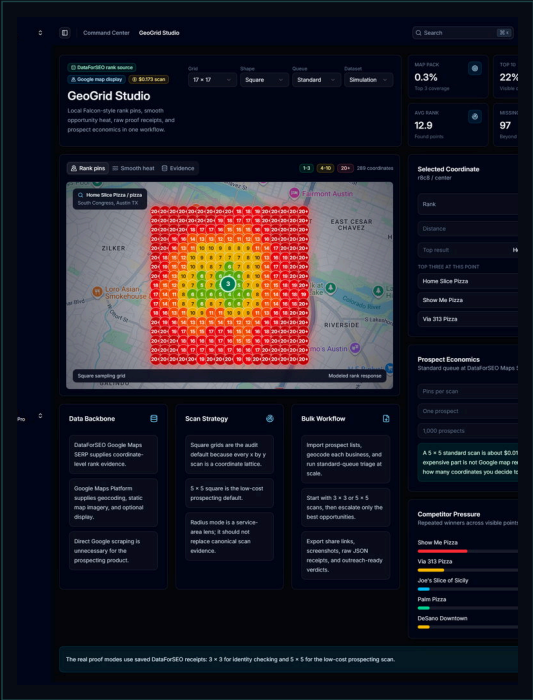


BUILD VS BUY VERDICT

We can build the heatmap engine ourselves.

The core product is not magic: DataForSEO supplies coordinate-level Google Maps ranking data, Google Maps supplies the map layer, and we own the dashboard, cache, scoring, screenshots, and PDF reports.



1,000 PROSPECTS, 5 X 5

\$15

Raw DataForSEO Standard Queue rank-check cost.

1,000 PROSPECTS, 9 X 9

\$48.60

Best use of a \$50 proof budget.

REAL PROOF SCAN

\$0.015

Home Slice Pizza 5 x 5 Standard run.

LOCAL FALCON PAYGO COMP

83x

25,000 credits at \$0.05 is \$1,250 vs \$15 raw data.

FIG. 01

The answer in plain English

Yes, this is realistic to build. The rank data is available through DataForSEO Google Maps SERP using a precise coordinate for each grid point. Google Maps is used for display and geocoding, not as the rank source.

The cheaper path is not free. It is cheaper because we are buying raw coordinate-level SERP data directly and building the product layer ourselves.

01

Geocode business and choose radius

02

Generate square coordinate grid

03

Run DataForSEO Maps SERP per coordinate

04

Parse target rank and render heatmap

FIG. 02

What we already proved

We ran a real DataForSEO Standard Queue scan for Home Slice Pizza in Austin on the keyword "pizza". The 5 x 5 run cost \$0.0150 and produced saved raw receipts, parsed grid data, and a dashboard view.

GRID

5 x 5

25 coordinate searches around the business.

VISIBILITY

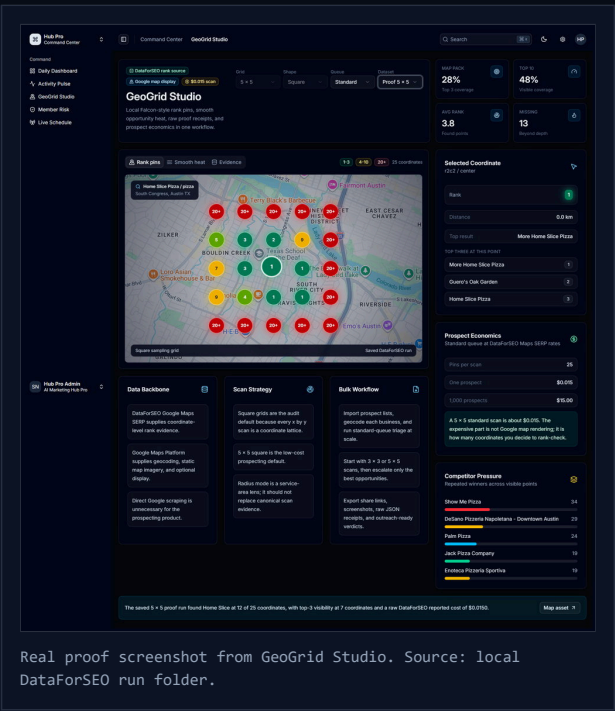
28%

Top 3 coverage across the scan area.

FOUND RANK

3.83

Average rank where the business appeared.



Real proof screenshot from GeoGrid Studio. Source: local DataForSEO run folder.

FIG. 03

The cost model

DataForSEO Standard Queue is the affordability mode. Priority doubles the cost. Live is about 3.33x Standard and should be reserved for demos or urgent checks.

GRID	STANDARD	PRIORITY	LIVE	1,000 PROSPECTS, STANDARD
3 x 3 9 pins	\$0.0054	\$0.0108	\$0.0180	\$5.40
5 x 5 25 pins	\$0.0150	\$0.0300	\$0.0500	\$15.00
7 x 7 49 pins	\$0.0294	\$0.0588	\$0.0980	\$29.40
9 x 9 81 pins	\$0.0486	\$0.0972	\$0.1620	\$48.60
15 x 15 225 pins	\$0.1350	\$0.2700	\$0.4500	\$135.00
17 x 17 289 pins	\$0.1734	\$0.3468	\$0.5780	\$173.40
21 x 21 441 pins	\$0.2646	\$0.5292	\$0.8820	\$264.60

FIG. 04

Expected ongoing costs

USE CASE	RUN SHAPE	RANK-DATA COST	READOUT
One-time prospecting proof	1,000 prospects, 5 x 5 Standard	\$15.00	Best first paid run if the list is real.
Premium prospecting proof	1,000 prospects, 9 x 9 Standard	\$48.60	Best use of a \$50 test budget.
Showpiece visuals	288 prospects, 17 x 17 Standard	\$49.94	Use for demo accounts, not full-list triage.
Monthly client monitoring	100 clients, 5 x 5 monthly	\$18.00 / month	Good agency baseline for retained clients.
Monthly client monitoring	100 clients, 9 x 9 monthly	\$58.32 / month	Better coverage while still inexpensive.
Quarterly refresh	1,000 prospects, 5 x 5, four times yearly	\$60.00 / year	Keeps cached prospect data from going stale.
Weekly deep tracking	25 clients, 9 x 9 weekly	\$63.18 / year	High signal for active campaigns.

Google Maps costs are secondary here. Static Maps, Dynamic Maps, and Geocoding each list a 10,000 monthly free usage cap on Google's pricing page. DataForSEO coordinate count is the real cost lever.

FIG. 05

Build vs buy

PATH	COMPARABLE SCOPE	COST SIGNAL	MEANING
Direct DataForSEO	1,000 prospects x 5 x 5	\$15.00 raw rank data	Rank source only. We supply UI, cache, scoring, and reports.
Local Falcon package route	Minimum listed monthly package that covers 25,000 credits is Pro	\$99.99 / month	About 6.7x the raw DataForSEO cost, but includes a finished SaaS workflow.
Local Falcon pay-as-you-go	25,000 credits at \$0.05 per credit	\$1,250.00	About 83x the raw DataForSEO cost. Useful only as a comparison floor.
Search Atlas	Starter subscription	\$99 / month, or \$79 displayed annual rate	Suite pricing, not heatmap-only pricing. Heatmap quota details were not isolated.

This is not an apples-to-apples attack on SaaS pricing. Local Falcon and Search Atlas include finished workflows. The point is that the raw rank-data backbone is cheap enough for us to build our own prospecting system.

FIG. 06

Square grid, radius, and why the shape looks rectangular sometimes

The paid scan should stay square because that is the repeatable sampling model: 3 x 3, 5 x 5, 9 x 9, 17 x 17. Radius controls how far the points extend from the center.

On a screen, the grid can look rectangular because the map viewport, latitude and longitude scaling, and screenshot crop are not a perfect physical square. The underlying coordinate lattice is still square in point count.

FIG. 07

Cache the paid run

If we pay for 1,000 prospects, we should never pay for the same scan twice unless freshness requires it. The bulk runner now fingerprints each scan before execution and writes a manifest, normalized CSV, vault note, and linked evidence paths.

VAULT

Index note

Human-readable run summary, freshness status, and source links.

WORK FOLDER

Raw receipts

DataForSEO request tasks, raw responses, parsed grids, and screenshots.

QUERY LAYER

JSONL or SQLite

Fast filtering for prospects, winners, weak zones, and competitor pressure.

FIG. 08

Risks and guardrails

MATCHING RISK

Use CID or place ID when possible

Name matching alone can miss a listing. Domain, CID, and place ID make the match stronger.

FRESHNESS RISK

Date every scan

Demo data can stay historical. Prospect outreach should usually refresh after 7 to 30 days.

Do not build a direct Google Maps scraper as the rank backbone. DataForSEO is the cleaner path because it absorbs the retrieval, proxy, CAPTCHA, and maintenance burden.

NEXT

The recommended move

Run the first paid bulk proof only on a real prospect list. Pick one vertical and geography, use 5 x 5 Standard for a \$15 proof, or use 9 x 9 Standard if we want the strongest 1,000-prospect proof inside a \$50 budget.

Use 15 x 15 or 17 x 17 for hero visuals, curated demos, and high-value prospects. Do not use them for first-pass triage across 1,000 prospects unless the extra cost is intentional.

Forwardable message: We tested the heatmap idea directly. DataForSEO gives coordinate-level Google Maps rankings, Google Maps gives the map display, and our dashboard/report layer makes it usable. A 5 x 5 scan is about \$0.015 per prospect, so 1,000 prospects is about \$15 in raw rank-check cost. Pay once on a real list, cache it, and reuse it for demos, screenshots, and outreach while it remains fresh.

Source trail

DataForSEO Google Maps SERP pricing https://dataforseo.com/pricing/serp/google-maps-serp-api	DataForSEO grid rank tracker method https://dataforseo.com/help-center/build-grid-rank-tracker-maps
Google Maps Platform pricing https://developers.google.com/maps/billing-and-pricing/pricing	Local Falcon pricing and credit model https://www.localfalcon.com/pricing
Local Falcon credit definition https://www.localfalcon.com/answers/101-what-is-a-credit	Search Atlas pricing https://searchatlas.com/pricing/
Search Atlas local SEO heatmap page https://searchatlas.com/local-seo-software/	paulmassen seo-playground https://github.com/paulmassen/seo-playground
nicosh react-geo-heatmap https://github.com/nicosh/react-geo-heatmap	